

tion age. An essential first step in that process is a time-bound upgradation of school infrastructure. Some estimates show that at least 15 per cent of over six million schoolteachers are ICT-literate. This is the base on which a platform can be built.

Healthcare is another sector where India's potential can be realised using the ICT. Medical tourism may be booming, but thousands die due to inadequate primary healthcare. We need more doctors, hospitals and beds to deal with that, but more importantly, we also need to equip more than a million healthcare workers and get across primary healthcare facilities to every Indian. The potential of scaling remote diagnostics and care (broadly called telemedicine) has been established through a variety of trials and pilot deployments. The confluence of advance in computing technology (high performance pcs), communications (broadband) and solutions (video conferencing) have made telemedicine a reality. An investment of Rs 5-10 lakh per primary health centre can be the agent of change. Taken together, a shift in policy treating education and healthcare as core infrastructure and a 1-2 per cent shift in budgetary allocation can make wonders happen with technology in three years.

Governance and government initiatives need to reach every citizen of the country. Through public-private partnerships, the Government can ensure that its policies are implemented effectively. E-governance initiatives like community service centres (CSC), automation of birth and death certifications, single window clearance systems, information kiosks and rural cyber cafes are transforming lives across the country. The importance of broadband connectivity for the success of these e-initiatives can't be emphasised enough. Development initiatives need to reach people across the country so that they can experience a better quality of life wherever they are and need not migrate to the over-crowded urban areas.

India's advent as a global power is incomplete

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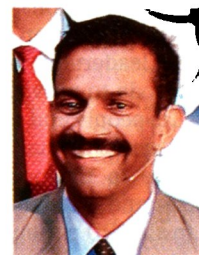


A HOLISTIC APPROACH THAT INCLUDES CURRICULUM ENABLED BY TECHNOLOGY AND INTERNET IS CRUCIAL TO DEVELOPING A WORKFORCE FOR THE INFORMATION AGE.

unless it does its bit in the area of resolving global warming. Progressive policies and incentives for developing clean energy and reducing consumption have to be part of the Government's agenda. Concepts like Energy Internet and Smart Grid, which help align individual consumption with regional and national capacity, need to be looked at so that we can get from developing to developed without making the same mistakes others did.

The collective impact of these investments, policy changes and public-private partnerships can only be measured in terms of improving the quality of life of every citizen. Every form downloaded at a village CSC that saves a farmer a hectic visit to the city, every bit of early medical intervention that lowers the burden on city hospitals and saves a life, every child that receives relevant education that makes them employable citizens, contributes to that quality of life.

India is at the threshold of being an economic superpower. With a stronger ICT backbone, we can cross the threshold faster. For that, we need aggressive goals. Going up the ICT readiness ranking is one way to set these goals. From 118 now, can we break into the top 50 in the next five years? If yes, we will be truly ahead on the path to Digital India.



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